Annotation Guidelines

MedBhasha · A Bengali Clinical NLP Hackathon

ROUND 1 RESOURCE — READ BEFORE YOU START ANNOTATING

Version 1.0 | Companion to `entity_schema.md` and `worked_example/`

1. Purpose of This Document

`entity_schema.md` defines *what* the ten entity categories mean. This document covers *how* to apply them consistently while annotating real notes — the workflow, the judgment calls you'll hit repeatedly, and the mistakes that most commonly cost teams points on annotation quality. Read this once before you start, then keep it open as a reference while you annotate.

This document is tool-agnostic. Whether you annotate in Label Studio, doccano, INCEpTION, a spreadsheet, or a custom script, the principles below are the same — only the mechanics of clicking/typing differ.

2. Before You Start

- ☐ Read `entity_schema.md` in full, including the Edge Cases section
- ☐ Open `worked_example/sample_note_raw.txt` and `sample_note_annotated.csv` side by side and trace through how each token was tagged
- ☐ Confirm your data sources are on the approved list (see Data Collection Rules) before annotating a single note — annotating disallowed data wastes your team's time, since it will be excluded at review regardless of annotation quality
- ☐ Decide on your output file path/structure now, matching the format in §4 of `entity_schema.md`, so you're not reformatting everything at the end

3. The Annotation Workflow

We recommend this order for each note, rather than annotating categories one at a time across many notes:

1. **Read the whole note once before tagging anything.** Clinical sentences are often short and context-dependent — a word's correct category can depend on something mentioned two sentences later.
2. **Tag spans left to right, one pass.** For each token, ask: is this part of an entity? If yes, which of the 10 categories, and is it the *first* token of that entity (`B-`) or a *continuation* (`I-`)?
3. **Re-read the note once more after tagging** to catch spans you tagged inconsistently with similar spans earlier in the same note.
4. **Run `validate.py` after every batch** (e.g., every 20–30 notes), not just once at the very end — catching a systematic mistake early saves you from re-tagging hundreds of notes later.

4. Core Principles

4.1 Tag the minimal span that carries the meaning

Include only the words that are actually the entity. Don't extend a span to cover neighbouring filler words out of convenience.

Text	Correct	Incorrect
রোগীর জ্বর আছে	জ্বর → `B-SYMPTOM`	`রোগীর জ্বর আছে` all tagged as one SYMPTOM span

4.2 Tag what the text says, not what you infer

If a note says "রক্তচাপ পরীক্ষা করা হয়েছে" (a blood pressure test was done) but doesn't state the result, do not invent a `TEST_RESULT` tag. Annotate only what is explicitly present in the text.

4.3 Be consistent within your own corpus

If you tag "রক্তচাপ পরীক্ষা" as a single `TEST` span in one note, tag the same phrase the same way everywhere else it appears in your corpus. Annotation quality is scored partly on agreement with a clinician-adjudicated gold sample — internal inconsistency is one of the fastest ways to lose points there, since it signals the schema wasn't applied systematically.

4.4 When genuinely unsure, decide and move on

Don't let one ambiguous phrase stall annotation for an entire session. Make the most defensible call per §2 of `entity_schema.md`, keep a short running note of ambiguous cases you hit often, and mention the pattern in your Round 1/final report if it recurs. If it's a genuinely new situation the schema doesn't cover, raise it as a GitHub issue so the answer is public for every team.

5. Common Mistakes to Avoid

Mistake	Why it hurts your score	Fix
Tagging only the head word of a multi-word entity (e.g., tagging only `৫০০` and leaving `মিগ্রা` as `O`)	Breaks entity-level F1 scoring in Part 2 — a partial span counts as wrong, not partially correct	Tag every token of the span: first token `B-`, rest `I-`
Mixing up `TEST` and `PROCEDURE` (e.g., tagging an X-ray as `PROCEDURE`)	Systematic category confusion lowers agreement with the gold sample across your whole corpus	Diagnostic/imaging → `TEST`. Therapeutic/interventional → `PROCEDURE`.

		See §2 of entity_schema.md
Extending a negation tag across the thing being negated	Inflates `NEGATION_UNCERTAINTY` span length incorrectly and miscategorizes the negated symptom/diagnosis itself	Tag only the negation marker itself; the negated entity keeps its own normal category tag
Inconsistent tag casing (`b-diagnosis` instead of `B-DIAGNOSIS`)	`validate.py` will reject these as unrecognized tags	Copy tag values exactly from §2 of `entity_schema.md` ; don't retype them by hand repeatedly
Skipping punctuation rows or leaving blank tag cells	Breaks the one-row-per-token format the validator and scoring scripts expect	Every token gets a row and a tag, even punctuation (tag it `O`)

6. Code-Mixed & Informal Text

Real Bengali clinical/health text often mixes Bengali script, English medical terms, and sometimes transliterated Bengali in Latin script ("Banglish"). Guidelines for this:

- Tag entities based on **meaning**, not script. An English drug name embedded in an otherwise Bengali sentence is still tagged `MEDICATION` .
- Tokenize code-mixed text the same way you'd tokenize monolingual text — by whitespace and punctuation boundaries, keeping each word as its own token/row.
- Spelling variation (e.g., different transliterations of the same drug name across notes) does not need to be normalized before annotation. Tag each occurrence as it appears in the source text; note spelling variation as a diversity signal in your EDA, not a problem to fix.

7. Self-Review Checklist (Before Submission)

- ☐ Ran `validate.py` on the final file with zero errors
- ☐ Spot-checked at least 10 random notes against `entity_schema.md` for consistency
- ☐ Confirmed every note has a matching entry in your source declaration
- ☐ Confirmed no note contains real patient-identifying information (see Data Collection Rules)
- ☐ Confirmed file columns are exactly `note_id, token, tag` and tag values match the schema exactly
- ☐ EDA summary reflects the final, validated version of the corpus (not an earlier draft)

8. Getting Help

If something in a real note doesn't clearly fit the schema, or you're unsure about a judgment call not covered in §4–6 above, open an issue in this repository rather than guessing privately. This keeps the ruling visible to every team and keeps scoring fair across the board. Check existing issues first — your question may already be answered.

> See `worked_example/` for a fully annotated sample note covering all ten entity categories, validated against the official `validate.py` script with zero errors — use it as your reference for exactly what a correct submission looks like.

Changelog

Version	Date	Change
1.0	[October 12, 2026]	Initial release